

So, they were not able to change the law. Now the Indian patent office is trying to authorise the software patents again by twisting the existing law. So, you really have to fight constantly to stop these companies from grabbing control.

Now, in the MS-Novell pact, Novell accepted a licence patent for Novell customers from Microsoft and Novell agreed to pay Microsoft a fee for usage. So, if you are a Novell customer you are paying Microsoft. Because of this, there is a boycott of Novell by free software activists who condemn this betrayal.

Q What do you say about censorship?

I should explain that this is not part of the free software issue. It's a much older issue of human rights. Censorship is an evil. It attacks your freedom and is very dangerous.

Q So, you mean there should not be any kind of censorship?

No, not at all. Now, I have seen things that disgusted me. For instance there was a movie, which was very famous and very popular, called *Pulp Fiction*. The violence in the movie disgusted me. If there is somebody bleeding on the street and I can help him, I guess I have to force myself to look. But if it is just fiction in a movie, why should I suffer?

However, I am against censorship. I do not want people to censor movies like *Pulp Fiction*. I am against it. I defend their freedom to make movies like these, and I am not going to go and watch them.

Q There has been a lot of concern regarding software as a service. What do you think?

Software as a service means that in order to do your computing, you are going to send your data to someone else's computer. There, he is going to run a program and your computing will be done in his computer and with his copy of a program. If the program is someone else's copy then the person who owns the copy takes away the control from you. Here you don't have control on your computing, so you must not do this. The only way you can have control of your computing is if you do it in your copy of a free program. But the structure of the problem is different.

Interestingly, in case of software as a service, it doesn't matter whether that guy's copy, which you are using, is free software or not, because if it is free software—that means he has control of the copy and not you. We can't say that you, we and everyone has to have control over his copy. Because he is entitled to control his copy. That means, when we do computing we should not use his copy; we should use our copy. That is the only way the user can have control. So, software as a service is simply bad and cannot be redeemed. Nothing can make it acceptable.

However, I want to point out that most servers are not software as a service. Most servers are just doing something and, in most cases, it's not you computing your data on that server. For example, if you visit *stalman.org*, you can read what I have published. That is not

software as a service. Or if you go to the free software directory at *directory.fs.org*, you can search our list of free programs. Well, that runs a program, but that is not software as a service. What you are doing is looking at our data. So there is no problem. Or suppose you go to a Web-store and buy something; what you are doing there is e-commerce and that is a mutual transaction between you and someone else. It is not you computing your data, so that is not software as a service. Suppose you help edit a Wikipedia page—what you are doing there is helping to do Wikipedia's computing. And that is not your computing on your data. It is not software as a service and it is fine. So, we should be aware when I condemn software as a service—out of all the websites in the world software as a service is a tiny fraction of them. It is a narrow way of using a server. Most Web servers are something else.

Q But when I am running a website, my data is on someone else's server and I don't even know where my data is.

That is a somewhat different issue. You can have your computer that is hosted by somebody and you can still have your copies of software. So, you still do control the computing that is done. True, you are trusting your data to whoever hosts the machine. He can go to the machine and rip off the data. It is trusting somebody, but at least he doesn't control the computing that you do.

Q But today people care about mobility; they don't want to carry their data. They want to access it from where ever they want.

That is silly! That means you are trusting your private data to someone you don't know you can trust. So, that is foolish, that is really dumb!

Q There shouldn't be any such thing?

I don't think you should do it. In many cases it goes hand-in-hand with software as a service. Consider the worst example, Google Docs. With Google Docs here is what happens: you keep your private data, or you wish it were private, on Google servers. So, you are trusting a multinational corporation with your privacy, which, of course, you can never trust—any of them for that matter. In order to use it, the site transmits a large proprietary program to your computer, which you may not realise as it happens invisibly – it's a Java script program and it gets loaded into your browser.

Aside from this, which is obviously wrong, there is also a large program that is an unreleased program running in Google servers, and Google, of course, controls it and you don't. So, this is absurd—you should have control of this computing. You should run your word processor or your spreadsheet on your computer. Don't run it on Google's computer or anyone else's. And I am not saying that Google is particularly worse, although it's true that they are. They should release that Java script